Imperial DoLS GTA Allocator
Guide for Practical/Course Directors

Overview

The GTA Allocator helps match PhD students to practical demonstrating sessions based on their preferences and expertise. This guide explains how to add your practicals, check live who has been allocated to them, and what happens to any places still empty after the allocation.

Website: https://tonysouthall.github.io/GTA_allocator/

Accessing the Admin Interface

1. Go to the GTA Allocator website
2. Click **"Convenor View"** in the top right
3. Enter your convenor password (*convenor2026#*) when prompted
4. You'll see the Convenor Dashboard

Note: The Convenor Dashboard lets you add, edit, and delete your practicals, and view student submissions. Running the allocation, sending allocation emails, managing vetoes, and clearing data are now handled centrally by the DPS through a separate DPS-only login - you don't need to (and can't) do these yourself. If you need any of these, contact the DPS.

Adding Your Practical

⚠️ **IMPORTANT: Add Practicals Early!**
Please add your practical details as soon as possible.
Why this matters:
• Students rank ALL available practicals in order of preference
• If your practical is added late, students may have already used their top preferences
• Early listing = better chance of getting well-matched, enthusiastic GTAs

Step-by-Step: Adding a Practical

In the Admin Dashboard, find the "Add Practical" section and fill in the details:

Field	What to enter
Practical Name	Clear, descriptive name (e.g., "Genetics Lab - PCR Techniques")
Module Code	Required. Must include the module code (e.g. LIFE50019); you can add the module name after it. The office uses it to charge GTA pay to the right module, and GTAs need it for their pay claims.
Practical Date	When the practical runs
Session Times	Enter a Morning session, an Afternoon session, or both (for a full day with a lunch break). Students see these times and the total hours before signing up.
Signup Deadline	When students must submit preferences by
GTA Slots	Number of demonstrators needed
📄 **Handbook URL**	Link to the practical handbook, shared so that anyone at Imperial

	can open it (see "Sharing Your Handbook Link" below). This is REQUIRED: students must read the handbook before their practical.
Convenor Email	Your email address. You will receive the GTA list automatically, and use it to view your live GTA list at any time.

Expertise Tags: select any tags relevant to your practical to help match students with suitable experience. If the tag you need isn't listed, type it into the **"Add another expertise tag"** box and click **Add tag**. It is saved with your practical and becomes available to everyone.

Expertise required: for specialist practicals (for example phylogenetics), tick **"Expertise required"** so that only GTAs with at least one of your selected tags can be allocated, including through the Open GTA slots page. Students who don't have the expertise can't be placed on it. Leave it unticked for general practicals, where tags only help with matching.

Sharing Your Handbook Link

Students must be able to open your handbook without requesting access. Link to the file itself, shared with everyone at Imperial:

1. Open the handbook (PDF or Word file) in OneDrive or SharePoint, or right-click it in the file list
2. Click **Share**, then open the link settings (the gear icon, or the text describing who the link works for)
3. Choose **People in Imperial College London** and set the permission to **Can view**, then click **Apply**
4. Click **Copy link**
5. Paste the link into the **Handbook URL** field when adding or editing your practical

> ⚠️ **Link to the file, not the site**
> Don't paste the address of a SharePoint site or document library (for example a link ending in ".../Forms/AllItems.aspx"). Students who aren't members of that site have to request access, and may not get it in time.
> If your practical has several documents (a schedule, worksheets), share the **folder** they are in the same way and paste the folder link instead.
> **Check it works:** ask a PhD student, or a colleague who doesn't have access to your files, to open the link before the practical.

Multi-Day Practicals

If your practical runs over multiple days, please add a separate entry for each day rather than one entry covering the whole block. This allows different students to be allocated to different days, spreading opportunities more fairly, rather than the same one or two GTAs covering the entire practical.
When adding each day:

- Use the same Module Code, Handbook URL, and Convenor Email across all entries
- Distinguish each entry in the Practical Name (e.g. *"Genetics Lab - Day 1"*, *"Genetics Lab - Day 2"*)

Tips for Good Practical Listings

- Use clear, specific names (not just "Week 3 Practical")
- Include the module code (e.g. LIFE50019) - the office uses it to charge GTA pay, and students need it for pay claims
- Always provide a handbook link - students are expected to read it before the practical
- Enter your convenor email to receive the GTA list automatically and to see your live GTA list
- Enter accurate Session Times — students see this as the advertised session length, and it sets their expectations for how many hours they'll be paid for

Special Circumstances for GTA Allocation

Specialised Allocation Requests

For specialist practicals where particular expertise or experience is needed, convenors may hand-pick a specific student(s) as a GTA(s). To keep this fair and to give other students a training opportunity, at least one additional GTA slot on that practical must still be filled through the normal GTA Allocator process rather than all slots being hand-picked.

Mature Students as GTAs

PhD students who are mature or returning students, or who are engaged in activities such as field courses during the term, may be eligible to serve as GTAs in specific circumstances. This requires agreement from both the student and the relevant Course Director, provided it would not negatively impact their degree. Please contact the DPS (James/Rozan in PhD Ops) if you wish to discuss this for a specific student. The relevant contacts are: James Ferguson/ Rozan Hamilton Nixon - PhD Ops

GTA Eligibility: DoLS Students Only

Only PhD students registered in the Department of Life Sciences (DoLS) are eligible to GTA for departmental practicals. Students from other departments are not eligible to sign up through the Allocator.

Vetoing a Specific Student

In specific circumstances (for example, where it is known that the student is not taking their responsibilities as a GTA seriously), a staff member may request that a specific student not be allocated to their practical sessions. To request a veto:

- Contact the DPS directly with the student email, your convenor email, and the reason
- Vetoes are applied in the allocation system before the algorithm runs
- This information is treated confidentially

After the Allocation

You Will Receive an Email

Once the DPS runs the allocation, you will automatically receive an email containing:

- Names and email addresses of your allocated GTAs, and whether each has confirmed
- Reserve GTAs (up to 2 per practical)
- Practical date, session times, location and course code
- A link to your live GTA list (see below)

> 📋 **Reserve GTAs**
> The system allocates up to 2 reserve GTAs for each practical. These are students who selected your practical but were not allocated as a main GTA.
> If one of your GTAs declines in the app, the first reserve is offered the place automatically and you are emailed. If a GTA drops out at very short notice, you can also contact a reserve directly (they are shown in your live GTA list).

Checking Your GTAs Live

You can check who is allocated to your practicals at any time, including confirmations, withdrawals and volunteers, in two places in Convenor View:

- **My GTAs (live)**, at the top of Convenor View: enter your convenor email once (it is remembered on your computer) to see each of your practicals with its GTAs' names, emails and status, how many GTAs are still needed, reserves, and anyone who has withdrawn. You can also download the list as a CSV.
- 👥 **GTAs button** on each practical in the Current Practicals list (green if fully staffed, amber if short): click it to see that practical's GTAs.

- Each practical also has an **Email these GTAs** link, which opens an email to all its current GTAs.

Your allocation email, and any email telling you a GTA has declined, includes a personal link that opens your live list directly (you will need the convenor password).

What the statuses mean:

- **Confirmed**: the GTA has confirmed they will attend
- **Awaiting confirmation**: emailed, but has not yet responded
- **Promoted from reserve**: offered the place after another GTA declined
- **Confirmed (volunteered)**: took an empty place through the Open GTA slots page

Empty Places After the Allocation

Once the main allocation has been run, any practical that still needs GTAs (for example after declines, or because it was added late) is listed on the **Open GTA slots** page, where registered PhD students can volunteer on a **first come, first served** basis. Volunteers are confirmed straight away, and you receive an email each time someone takes one of your places. Students cannot take a place that clashes with another of their sessions.

The DPS can also fill places directly, and may help recruit for sessions that remain uncovered. Sessions next term are not listed until that term's allocation has been run.

Practicals added after the allocation are open for sign-up and appear on the Open GTA slots page. Students are no longer emailed automatically each time a practical is added, so if you add one late, let the DPS know so it can be advertised.

Emails You Will Receive

- After the allocation: your GTA list
- When a GTA declines: who declined, and which reserve (if any) has been offered the place
- When a student volunteers for, or the DPS fills, one of your empty places
- When the DPS removes or replaces one of your GTAs
- After the practical: an optional invitation to rate your GTAs

GTA Ratings

After the practical, GTAs are invited to rate their experience. Ratings and comments are visible to the DPS in the Admin Dashboard. You may be contacted if significant feedback is provided about your practical.

Rating Your GTAs

After the practical, you will also receive an automatic email inviting you to rate each of your GTAs individually (1–5 stars, plus an optional comment). This is optional. Ratings are visible only to the DPS — not to other convenors, and not to the GTAs themselves — and may help inform future allocation decisions if a consistent pattern emerges over time.

GTA Pay and Prepwork

GTAs are not paid for time spent preparing for a practical unless you, as the convenor, have agreed this with them in advance. If you expect GTAs to complete preparation beyond reading the handbook, please agree and communicate any paid prep time directly with your GTAs before the practical.

Reporting the Actual Practical Duration

When adding a practical, you'll enter advertised Session Times - students see this before signing up. After each practical has run, please also report back to the DPS how long the session actually lasted. This helps ensure GTA pay claims accurately reflect time worked, particularly if a session runs shorter or longer than advertised.

GTAs and Summative Marking

GTAs should not be asked to carry out summative marking. Their role is to support students during the practical session; any summative assessment of student work remains the responsibility of academic staff.

Editing or Deleting Practicals

To Edit: Find your practical in the list, click "Edit", make changes, click "Save Changes"

To Delete: Find your practical, click "Delete", confirm when prompted

About the Allocation

> ⚠️ **Do not run the allocation yourself unless instructed by DPS**
> The allocation should be run centrally by the DPS to ensure all practicals for the term have been added and all deadlines have passed.

How the algorithm works:

- Equal distribution - everyone gets one slot before anyone gets a second
- Priority to students with fewer previous hours — fair opportunity for all
- Respects preferences - tries to give everyone their top choices
- Only places students on practicals they selected (unless they opted in to others)
- No timetable clashes - a GTA is never given two overlapping sessions
- Reserve allocation - up to 2 backup GTAs per practical, offered the place automatically if a GTA declines
- Vetoed students - automatically excluded from the relevant convenor's practicals

Recommended Timeline

When	Action
Start of term	Add all known practicals for the term
Once all practicals added & preferences submitted	Allocation run by DPS
After allocation	**You receive email with GTA list**
Throughout term	Check your live GTA list; empty places are filled through Open GTA slots, and you are emailed as they fill

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: How do I know which students have been allocated to my practical?
A: You receive an automatic email after the allocation is run, and you can check your live GTA list at any time in Convenor View (My GTAs, or the 👥 GTAs button on each practical).

Q: What if a GTA can't make it on the day?
A: GTAs should decline in the app as early as possible; the first reserve is then offered the place automatically and you are emailed. For last-minute problems, contact a reserve directly; their details are in your live GTA list.

Q: I didn't receive the allocation email — what should I do?
A: Check your spam/junk folder. If it's not there, verify the convenor email address is correct in your practical listing, or contact DPS. You can also check your live GTA list in Convenor View at any time.

Q: What if not enough students selected my practical?
A: Unfilled places are listed on the Open GTA slots page, where registered students can volunteer first come, first served, and you are emailed as places fill. Contact the DPS if places remain uncovered close to the date.

Q: Students say they can't open my handbook. What should I do?
A: The link probably points to a SharePoint site or library rather than the file. Re-share the file (or its folder) with "People in Imperial College London" and "Can view", and update the Handbook URL (see "Sharing Your Handbook Link").

Q: How do I make sure only suitably experienced GTAs are allocated?
A: Select the relevant expertise tags (adding your own if needed) and tick "Expertise required" on your practical. Only students with a matching tag, or matching experience in their free-text description, can then be allocated.

Q: Can I request that a student not be assigned to my practical?
A: Yes. Contact the DPS to request a veto for exceptional circumstances (e.g. supervisory relationships). The veto is applied confidentially before the allocation runs.

Q: A mature student has approached me about being a GTA for my practical — is that allowed?
A: Potentially yes, in specific circumstances, provided both you and the student agree and it would not impact their degree. Please contact the DPS.

Need Help?

Contact the Director of Postgraduate Studies:
Tony Southall — t.southall@imperial.ac.uk